# The intermittent fasting challenge

A weekly break from eating as a mindful personal experiment. Notice how you feel and adapt it to your life. Fasting is not essential and is not suitable for everyone.

## A mindful break from eating

Once a week – with enough fluids, a calm approach and a mindful return to eating.

Weekly · flexible

## A possible schedule

Aim: 16–18 hours

Once a week

Water & unsweetened tea

Previous day · 5 pm

Have your last meal calmly, without making it unusually large. The fasting period begins afterwards.

Evening & morning

Drink water or unsweetened tea. Do not dry fast; consider avoiding intense exercise.

Following day · 11 am

Break the fast with a normal, well-tolerated meal. Eat slowly and notice your fullness.

Afterwards

Return to regular, balanced meals. Do not compensate or overeat to make up for the fast.

Note the timing:

5 pm to 11 am is exactly 18 hours. If you finish eating at 3 pm, the break until 11 am the next day lasts 20 hours. To stay within 16–18 hours, finish your last meal between 5 pm and 7 pm.

## Potential benefits of fasting

Fasting temporarily changes the availability of energy and nutrients. This can involve interesting biological adaptations – how strongly they occur varies between people, and the science is not yet conclusive in every area.

## Autophagy – cellular recycling

Autophagy is the body's cellular recycling process: cells break down and reuse damaged or no-longer-needed components. Nutrient scarcity can stimulate this process in cell and animal models. It has not yet been firmly established whether a single 16–18-hour fast measurably increases autophagy in humans.

## Mitophagy – mitochondrial quality control

Mitophagy is the selective removal of damaged or poorly functioning mitochondria. It is a specialised form of autophagy and helps maintain cellular quality control. However, it has not been shown that a weekly fasting window reliably increases this process in humans.

## Metabolism & metabolic flexibility

During a fasting window, insulin levels generally fall temporarily and the body increasingly draws on stored energy. Regular fasting patterns may improve body weight and some metabolic markers in certain people. Outcomes also depend on overall diet, energy balance and the fasting schedule.

## Clarity & mindful eating

Some people report feeling mentally clear or more mindful about meals while fasting. This is subjective and not universal: others experience hunger, fatigue or difficulty concentrating. Research has not established a consistent overall cognitive benefit.

What the evidence tells us

Research on autophagy and mitophagy in humans is still at an early stage. An exploratory 2025 study found a between-group difference in one autophagy measure after six months of a substantially more intensive fasting programme, but no significant increase from baseline within the fasting group. This does not establish an autophagy effect from one weekly 18-hour fast. Mental clarity is not guaranteed either.

Safety first

Not suitable, among others, for minors, people who are pregnant or breastfeeding, anyone with a current or past eating disorder, underweight, or certain medical conditions or medications (e.g. diabetes medication). Check with a healthcare professional first if you have a condition or are unsure. Stop if you feel dizzy, shaky, weak or unwell. This challenge is not medical advice.